

Make Ezio bucks

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Assassin's Creed was built up as the hottest new IP when it released in 2007. It promised to revolutionise the open world action-adventure genre with Parkour-like platforming, stealth, and a unique game world set in the 12th century. The game however, failed to live up to the hype and although it received praise for its originality, it was universally criticised for its repetitive structure. Fortunately, the game sold very well, paving the way for a sequel and a second chance for Ubisoft to deliver on its promises.

If *Assassin's Creed* was a statement of intent, then *Assassin's Creed 2* is a realisation of those intentions, and for anyone who loved the idea behind the first game, but lamented its lacklustre implementation, the sequel will not disappoint. *AC2* has all the qualities of a great sequel; it irons out all the faults from the original, while building upon everything that made it great. While you played Altair in the first game, this time you play the more flamboyant Ezio, and the setting moves from 12th century Middle East to a more beautiful Renaissance Italy.

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9



ASSASSIN'S CREED

Reviewer: Ubisoft

Genre: Action-adventure

Platforms: Xbox 360, PS3 (Rs 2,599). PC version delayed till March 2010



The characters from both games do share similarities. They're both assassins, after all; they dress similarly and share similar physical abilities. Ezio, however, has a wider range of weapons to choose from. He now has smoke bombs, throwing knives, and various other means to take on enemies. Money also plays a role and revenue earned from renovating and upgrading businesses in his hometown can be used to buy better weapons and armour, and even to hire courtesans, thieves, and mercenaries to help you in your missions.

While some missions are similar, there are enough variations in them to not feel monotonous. From thrilling chase sequences through narrow streets and rooftops to the challenging assassins' tombs puzzles to the main assassination missions, there is plenty of variety to make each mission feel fresh.

Then there are the side missions and collectibles; a standard inclusion in all open-world games. It really is an achievement when a game makes you want to complete optional tasks. Side missions are a mix of delivery missions, assassination contracts, rooftop races, and roughing up unfaithful husbands, and these missions yield cash rewards. But it's the collectibles that will keep you playing long

after you've completed the main story. Codex pages are pieces of a puzzle that you must collect throughout the game, however collecting these is compulsory to progress the story. Viewpoints are tall building strewn around the various cities and climbing them will add more objectives to your map. Then there are glyphs hidden on various landmarks. On finding them you're required to solve some very challenging puzzles. Each puzzle unlocks a few seconds of a video clip, and finding all glyphs unlocks a rather interesting video.

So the missions are fun and the side quests and collectibles are engaging as well, but the icing on the cake in *Assassin's Creed 2* is the locations. As you play in Renaissance Italy, you will travel through a few Italian cities, but none more stunning than Venice. The city is painstakingly detailed, teeming with a busy population, and it's a joy to navigate around with its network of canals and rich architecture. The inclusion of a day and night cycle further adds to the beauty.

You could argue that some of the missions feel like filler material, but on the whole, *Assassin's Creed 2* is a game with few faults. It delivers on every promise that the first game made but failed to uphold, and like any good sequel should, it raises the bar in just about every area. **d**